

Groundwork, the background intellectual property

What the practice brought to the engagement, what it built alongside it for its own method, and what it does not claim. 9 September 2026. The canonical copy sits beside the practice's rate card and carries no figure; the shareable copy is derived from it by a script that refuses to write if a client name or a figure has crept in.

The contract between the practice and Juno carves out the contractor's pre-existing tools and methodologies and assigns work product created specifically under a statement of work. It says nothing about the middle: the working method built inside the engagement, not a deliverable, and what a further market would inherit. This document names that middle so the next conversation starts from a shared description rather than two recollections. It is a description, not a proposal.

What the method is

Groundwork turns a field week into an evidence base a client can rely on, run the same way in every market so a later market inherits what an earlier one learned. It is best described as what happens to a recording. A conversation is recorded and transcribed. Its speakers are named against stored voiceprints, a person checks the naming by ear, and the file is filed under a name that carries its market, language and consent status. Every factual claim goes onto a register with who said it, where, what it rests on, and a verdict; a held claim never reaches a page the client sees. A figure carries its source onto any surface that shows it, and where a conversation happened in another language the surface says how it became English. A clearance rule settles what can be said to whom. A set of checks runs in one command and stops a send that would fail any of them. A close-out will not let a market finish until what it taught is written down where the next market will find it.

The method is that sequence, with the rules and tests that hold it in place. It is not any market's facts.

What predates the engagement, or stands independent of it

The practice arrived with a working stack and a set of estate conventions, and used both throughout. The stack is its own instructions for producing documents, decks, spreadsheets and PDFs, closing a session and writing a handover, guarding a citation, scrubbing a document before it is shared, transcribing audio, and adjudicating open questions on one surface. The conventions are the rules every project runs by: a fact has one owner and the owner is code that reads it from source; a status is derived from the artifact that settles it, never kept by hand; every handover leads with how to pick it up; every session ends with a close-out that leaves the record current; nothing lives loose at the root of a tree. None of it was written for this engagement, and none of it holds the client's facts.

The partnership workspace, where the practice's own planning and product work for Groundwork lives, sits under no statement of work. It opened after the engagement began, but it is the practice planning its own future work, not work product for a deliverable.

The engagement template

The practice keeps a generalised scaffold for an engagement of this kind: the folder shape, the naming rules, the vocabulary a market carries from the day it is created, the guards a build has to clear, and the close-out. The practice claims this template as its method, and says plainly that it was generalised during this engagement. It was not carried in finished; it was drawn out of the work as the work proved which parts were the method and which were one client's facts. The client's engagement was the first instance; the template is what remains when that instance's facts are lifted out.

What was built during the engagement, for the method

The contract does not name this middle, so it is described here by class rather than by list; a list changes as the estate is cleaned and would be stale by the time it was read.

The first class is the operating system: the gates a surface must pass before it can be sent, the census that measures the estate and says which parts are portable, the hygiene ratchet, the manifest, and the table of figures that says how each may be worded.

The second class is the intake pipeline: the drop folder, the transcription, the naming of speakers against stored voiceprints, the ear-check page, and the filing rule that names a tape once.

The third class is the register machinery: the shape of the register, the rule that ties a figure on a slide to the tape or document it came from, the note on how a foreign-language conversation was rendered, and the generators that read the register onto a dashboard, a spreadsheet or a client export.

The fourth class is the generators for boards, decks and dashboards, the design system they share, and the rule that a client surface never prints an internal label.

The fifth class is the working instructions written during the engagement: how to prep a call, run the intake, guard a citation, the voice and the brand, sweep the folders and pass the roster weekly.

The sixth class is the session record: the handovers, the state log, the project instructions and the close-out cascade. These are the practice's account of its own way of working. They hold the client's facts, which are confidential under the confidentiality clause rather than owned under the assignment clause.

Two qualifications. Much of the code in the first four classes still carries the client's vocabulary, because it was written in the room; that is a cleaning task the practice is paying down, not an ownership question. And a rendered board is not the generator that rendered it: the board, with the client's rows on it, is commissioned; the generator is the method.

What is not claimed

The practice does not claim any deliverable, in any draft or version, nor any recording, transcript, photograph, footage or interview note. It does not claim any register row, because a row is a fact about a market and the market's facts are the client's. It does not claim any film in any cut, any rendered board, dashboard or export that carries the client's rows, the record of the people met in the field, or anything the client furnished. And it does not claim the description of the method that the statement of work's final phase delivers to the client: that knowledge-transfer package describes the practice, carries

blank templates of its artefacts, and changes hands on delivery whatever the code does. The description travels; the machinery does not travel by that clause.

This document does not propose a licence or describe the shape one might take. It puts no value on anything and carries no rate. It does not say which version of the contract's intellectual-property clause was executed; that is a separate check against the signed copy. It is the practice's description of its own background intellectual property, offered so the next conversation can be about terms rather than definitions.

Shared for discussion. A description of background intellectual property, not a proposal, a licence or a valuation. Derived unchanged from the practice's canonical copy.